



→ that this won't get them anywhere when the growth numbers did not follow the big expectations. They decided to strip the product down to its best features – the photos. And so, Instagram was born. They got the lenses up and running, which would add some much needed gloss (and maybe a little too much) to an otherwise one-trick-pony. And then they exploded – nine million users in the first 10 months meant that it was only a matter of (a relatively short amount of) time that they became a headline. An eye-watering \$1 billion dollars exchanged hands as Facebook decided to take the plunge to acquire it.

PayPal

PayPal is one of those names who probably do not mean much to the average passive internet user. But because we have taken it upon ourselves to rid the world of average passive users, we tell you that PayPal is one of the largest payment handlers of online transactions. You would know if you've ever given as much as a passive glance to eBay. And that is not by some coincidence, eBay paid \$1.5 billion for the service in 2002, but that was not before the company changed the name from Confinity, and stopped providing cryptographic solutions for money transfer over Palm 'Pilots'. They switched



over to adding a layer of mail based abstraction for exchange of money, a move that brought with itself widespread acclaim, acceptance, and eventually \$windfall\$

BlackBerry

A determined fight for survival has always been respected since the advent of time. True warriors have always valued and appreciated the grit of the adversary that puts up a brave front, puts up a tough fight. About half a decade ago, Research in Motion was a true behemoth, enjoying the attention of governments, enterprise and consumers alike. No one would've ever

imagined, in their wildest dreams that one day it would be fighting for its very existence. But fast forward to today and you'd realise how things have changed. Their cofounders moved out, it got rid of excess headcount, and quarter after quarter of the media and analysts writing them off, BlackBerry, as the company is now renamed, has turned a new page in its long, illustrious history.

All is not well yet, since it also now seems to be the most lucrative acquisition target. Nevertheless, the brave fight for existence as well as example of innovation and creation it has set for the industry that is so busy accusing each other of patent violations is impressive. Yes, a company, whose signature product was based on Java, has been reengineered and redesigned with the future of mobile computing in mind.

Research in Motion acquired QNX to gain access to a powerful and stable RTOS that enjoys dominance across automobile dashboards including Mercedes Benz



* Surprising pivots of history

- Yelp was an email recommendation service. But people started filling it up on reviews of the items on the site, which is when they shifted to crowd-sourced reviewing.
- Nokia was a paper manufacturing company
- Microsoft was essentially based on Gates' interpreter writing skills, and it grew into, well, this behemoth that we know today
- Apple went from making DIY computer parts, to making the most non-DIY tech products of all time
- Sony famously was a rice-cooker maker, whose initial cooker prototypes were terrible
- YouTube was an online video-based dating service
- Coca-Cola was a patented medicinal entity
- Nintendo started out by making card-based games, before crossing over to the tech side
- Fab.com was a social network for gay men
- Wipro was initially set up as a vegetable oil manufacturer in 1945. Incidentally, Wipro stood for Western India Palm Refined Oil Ltd. The company logo still contains a sunflower to reflect their original business.

and Porsche in addition to over 200 million car dashboards across the globe.

What this gives access to is innovation in the way we consume technology, according to the senior leadership at BlackBerry, the renewed Research in Motion.

Going by the announcements at this year's BlackBerry Live in Orlando, Florida, the confidence the team and developers have entrusted the new platform with is evident by the number of applications available at launch and their subsequent growth. All of this is encouraging to say the least. In less than six months, the platform has witnessed two major software updates as well (something unheard of before)! A competitive industry is always good for consumers.

To sum up...

All this is not to say that name changes accompanied the most high profile pivots in the world. In fact, most aren't as dramatic as we've discussed here. But a true pivot in today's Silicon Valley style of tech, it is just plain cool to just spin a different name, and do something cool, and then keep on doing cool things until one thing is too cool to be ignored. Cheers to that. 🍷